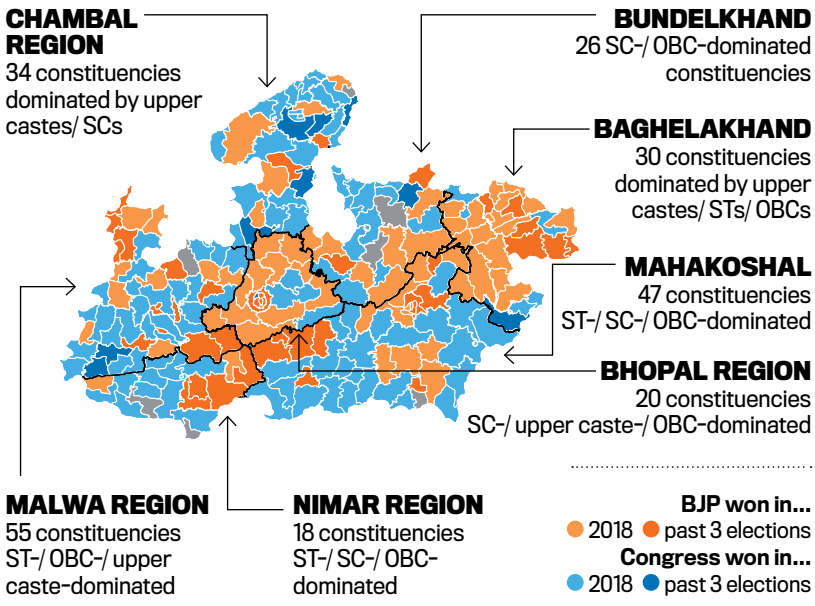
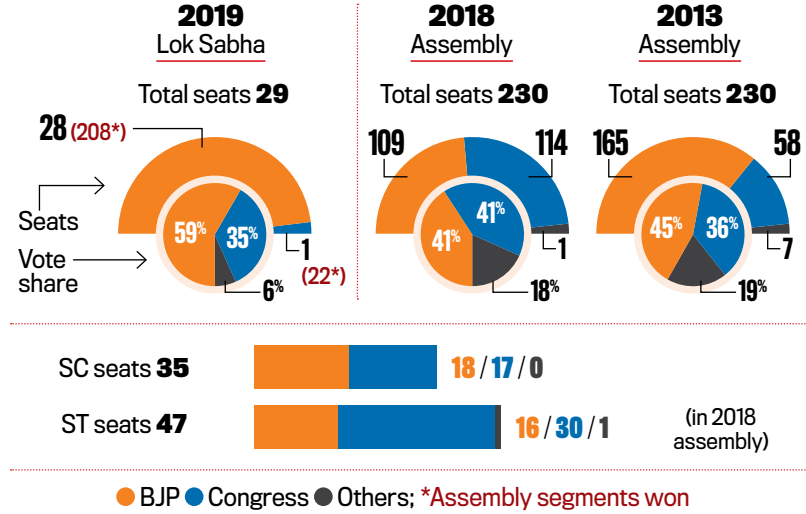
THE BATTLEGROUND

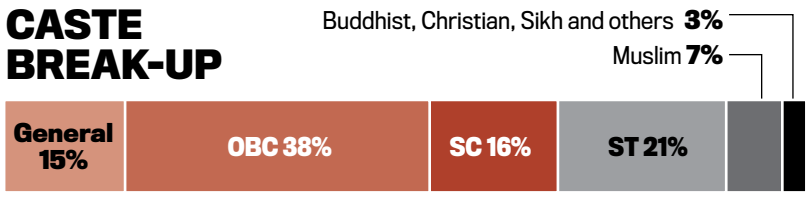
THERE ARE 56 ASSEMBLY SEGMENTS IN MP, INCLUDING 12 SC AND 10 ST SEATS, WHERE THE BJP HASN'T LOST THE PAST THREE ELECTIONS. THE CONGRESS HAS ACHIEVED THIS FEAT IN 10 SEATS WITH 1 SC AND 3 ST SEATS AMONG THEM



HOW THE TWO PARTIES PERFORMED



CASTE BREAK-UP



Source: Election Commission of India; Caste and region break-up with inputs from Axis My India and India Today bureau

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY *and* ASIT ROY

egy that had fetched the BJP handsome gains at the hustings in recent years. These three states, with a massive OBC population, are set to serve as the laboratories for the Congress to test its biggest poll plank—a nationwide caste census. If the party pulls it off, it will also be a hat trick of wins—after Himachal Pradesh and Karnataka—for Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge.

For Prime Minister Modi and the BJP, these state elections will be a test of the Vikasit Bharat narrative, the (till now) successful formula of wooing OBCs but subsuming caste identities under a wider Hindu umbrella and a broader 'beneficiary class', and the merits of a double-engine sarkar. PM Modi will be the face in all three states, relegating the state leadership to the background, even if the experiment failed in Himachal and Karnataka.

EVEN IF BJP LOSES THE STATE POLLS IT'S FIGHTING IN PM MODI'S NAME, THE OUTCOME IS UNLIKELY TO DENT HIS VOTE-CATCHING POWER IN THE LS POLLS

In fact, between 2015 and 2023, the party has lost 10 assembly polls where Modi campaigned extensively, exposing his diminishing cachet in state elections even if their outcomes does not dim his vote-catching power in parliamentary polls. That said, the PM will certainly want to end the year on a winning note.

The Congress, on the other hand, is letting its state lieutenants run the show. Even so, the results of these polls will be a validation of Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra, during which he spent considerable time in these states. Wins here may even inspire the Gandhi scion to embark on a second leg—from the east to the west—and place him in a better position to take on Modi in 2024.

With so much at stake, both parties are approaching the polls with gladiatorial zeal, deploying almost diametrically opposite tactics, making this duel for supremacy in states endlessly intriguing.